

ARABIA!

Volume Blueprints

Working series bible — Volumes II through VII

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Arabia-Series-Blueprints_v2 — internal, not for publication

v2 revision notes

This updates Arabia-Volume-Blueprints.pdf to v2. The principal change is Volume V, now reconciled in full with the finished Book Five manuscript (Arabia_Bk5_v16) and its detailed blueprint (Arabia_Bk5_Blueprint_v2). Other volumes retain their series-bible substance; only handoff language touching Volume V has been aligned. Two facts were corrected series-wide to match the drafted book: the working title of Book Five is now Veil Upon Veil (subtitle: The Ledger and the Well), and the keeper Talal dies in the winter of 1891 (the year of Mulayda), not c. 1895.

The series in one page

The Arabia! saga follows one family — the Al Ghanim, keepers of the wells at Ghadir in eastern Nejd — across thirteen centuries, from the digging of the first well c. 584 CE to the assassination of King Faisal in 1975, with codas into the 1990s. The family breaks in two in Volume I: the elder son keeps the rope at Ghadir; the younger rides west, and three generations on his line reaches al-Andalus. For eight hundred and seventy years the two branches do not meet; in Volume III, over coffee at Ghadir, they are reunited. The word for what has happened is al-jabr — the restoration of what was broken, and the root of algebra — and the saga is quietly named by its hidden mathematics. Beside the family runs a second lineage: a silsila of poems moving mouth to mouth across the same centuries. Imru' al-Qais's Mu'allafa, recited at Ghadir in Volume I, is written down at Ha'il in Volume V by Lady Anne Blunt — and is the same poem.

Load-bearing line earned in Volume V

“No one is born a slave. They only tell you that you were.” — Wadha to Khamis.

VOLUME II — THE WESTERN ROAD

The western branch rides out; the silsila and the travelling objects begin their long journey. Hands off toward the Andalus centuries and the mathematical inheritance that will later return as al-jabr without the word.

VOLUME III — THE BEAN AND THE SULTAN

The branches reunite at Ghadir over coffee; trade and the courtly world press on the wells; poetry and marriage threads thicken. Hands off with the household's buried and carried inheritances intact for the reform century.

VOLUME IV — THE PACT

Era 1744–1818. At Diriyah a preacher and a prince sign a pact; at Ghadir a keeper is forced to break grave, amulet, and (in appearance) a book of devotion. A younger Ghanim son goes to Bahrain, becomes a nakhoda, and dies at sea in 1811 — the pearl-coast wound that sends Fahd inland and that Volume V lives from below. Hands off: 1818; Mariam sends Hamad's son inland; the note sealed in the dark.

VOLUME V — THE EXILE (expanded)

Book Five title: Veil Upon Veil (subtitle: The Ledger and the Well)

Era 1818–1902 (substance between the 1830s and January 1902, on a bridge out of Book Four's 1818). Anchor places: Ghadir; Zeila and Berbera; the Red Sea dhow routes and Suez; the Gulf pearl beds; Kuwait under the Al Sabah; Ha'il under the Rashidis; Riyadh and the Masmak. Pressing from the water: steamship, Suez Canal (1869), telegraph to the Gulf in the 1860s.

Status: complete draft, nineteen chapters in four parts, 47,767 words; ~195–215 pages at 6×9 in EB Garamond 13.5; issued also as an EPUB with a clickable table of contents. This is the moral center of the saga and the pearl volume — the last great pre-oil Gulf economy at its peak, lived from below — and the volume where Arabian horse/asil culture reaches the page.

The story in one line

An African boy is bought at the coast, walked into the desert, and freed by a family that had never freed anyone before; his life carries the whole nineteenth century — pearl boom and debt-machine, steamship and wire, a sister swallowed by a trade going quietly underground, poems learned across a marriage, asil horse-knowledge, the veil a freed woman may wear and a slave may not, and the slow return of the Al Saud — until, on a January night in 1902, he holds a horse's bridle while a young man goes over a wall in Riyadh.

What is new or now settled in v2

- Title: Veil Upon Veil / The Ledger and the Well. The phrase is from the volume's own ode (Imru' al-Qais) and is earned in Chapter 8.
- The veiling custom is a major thread: free women veil, the enslaved are kept uncovered; Wadha's first veil comes with manumission (Ch 4); the “veil upon veil” night apex (Ch 8) fuses the ode, the freedom-veil, and grief; the Gulf battula gives coast texture (Ch 13).
- Talal dies in the winter of 1891, the year of Mulayda (corrected from c. 1895).
- The third-child strand is settled: Yaqt (youngest) dies the first winter; Faraj (middle) is sold onward with no grave and becomes the first face in Khamis's “room of faces.”
- The escort/two-camels silence — Khamis's unprovable certainty that Munira was sold a second time on the road — is planted early and resolved in Chapter 19: spoken once between husband and wife, kept from the children, with Munira's ultimate fate still unknown.
- The Masmak is seen only from outside the wall: Khamis holds the horses, does not enter the killing room, and learns the spear-and-notch from the men's later telling.

Key characters

- (invented) Khamis (b. c. 1840 Horn, d. 1932) — freed 1858; searches for Munira; one pearl summer; holds horses in 1902.
- (invented) Wadha (b. c. 1840, d. 1924) — freed with him; speaks the series line; keeper of the poems; first to veil at manumission.
- (invented) Munira — the sister the escort does not deliver; never found.

- (invented) Talal ibn Nasir (b. c. 1825, d. 1891) — frees them at real cost; dies the winter the state falls.
- (invented) Uthman (b. 1868) — loves Sultana, never speaks; learns of her death two years late.
- (invented) Fahd; Nura; Yaqut; Faraj; Salih; Ghazi; and Dhaidan of the horse-people.
- (composite) Sultana bint Nawwaf — a Rashidi commander's daughter; dies in childbirth, 1899.
- (historical) Doughty; the Blunts; Muhammad ibn Rashid; Mubarak al-Sabah; Abdulrahman; Abdulaziz (Ibn Saud); Percy Cox (bridge to VI).

Chapter architecture (nineteen chapters, four parts)

Part One — The Wilderness Generation: 1 After the Guns; 2 The Other Shore; 3 The Trade Learns to Whisper; 4 Grace That Costs.

Part Two — The Century's Engines: 5 Paid on Delivery; 6 The Pearl Summer; 7 Marzuq; 8 Dates and Verses; 9 The English Thirst.

Part Three — The Flight: 10 Sultana; 11 Recite the Dams; 12 Mulayda; 13 The Soft City; 14 Two Years Late; 15 The Horse-Holder's Boy.

Part Four — The Gate: 16 The Bill for Going; 17 Choosing the Quiet Ones; 18 Forty Men; 19 A Week Without Speech.

Objects that travel; poetry

The dark pearl (Zeila c. 1855 → raid-eve → homecoming); the freedwoman's veil; the water-tally cords; the buried chest (resealed, waits for 1969); the unused astrolabe; the 1818 note (not opened here); the three false names. Featured ode: Imru' al-Qais's Mu'allafa — public domain, rendered afresh; the echo lands without a character explaining it.

Where Volume V hands off

The Third Saudi State is founded; Khamis is sixty-two and will live thirty more years. Volume VI brings an Englishman with a motorcar and a camera to Kuwait; the pearl world against Mikimoto's beads; the Ikhwan as an engine that cannot be told to idle; and young Ghazi holding horses for Shakespear the way Khamis once held them for a boy who became a king. Percy Cox's name on the wind is the first thread.

VOLUME VI — THE ENGLISHMAN AND THE BRETHREN

Era 1914–1932. An English captain drives a motorcar into the desert to meet a king who does not yet exist; the pearl industry that fed Arabia for a thousand years collapses under a Japanese man's beads; a movement of holy warriors is built as an engine that cannot be told to idle; and in 1929 the king turns his machine guns on the men who put him where he is. Ghazi meets Shakespear at Kuwait as a boy handling horses — the Volume V handoff collected. Khamis dies at Ghadir in 1932. Hands off toward the oil century.

VOLUME VII — THE BLACK WATER

Era 1933–1975, with a coda into the 1990s. Oil, borders, and the family's late reckonings; objects and poems

from earlier volumes meet. The Californians arrive by the same logic Volume V taught: the future comes by machine along the water. Hands off into coda and silence.

Cross-reference

Detailed Volume V drafting bible: Arabia_Bk5_Blueprint_v2.docx. Working manuscript: Arabia_Bk5_v16.docx (complete draft) and Arabia_Bk5_v16.epub (e-book with clickable TOC). This v2 supersedes Arabia-Volume-Blueprints.pdf for all Volume V planning; the older word counts and the thin Part Three/Four architecture there are obsolete.

— End of Arabia-Series-Blueprints v2 —